without having to refer either to Eastern Command or Army HQ, his two sensational statements—that the Chinese were streaming down from the mountains and that Chinese paratroopers were about to land in North Assam—sent even the most stout-hearted citizen scurrying southwards to cross the Brahmaputra by bridge or by ferry. It is highly unlikely that he even once glanced at the notes given to him for the defence of Assam; instead he ordered the immediate evacuation of Corps HQ. That the civil administration would follow hard on the heels of the army was but natural. These tragic events culminated with Kaul heroically staying back in Tezpur on the night of 19 November with just his BGS, K. K. Singh, for company after sending everyone else away. In his mind, Kaul had played the role of 'the boy who stood on the burning deck' perfectly.

If all this wasn't bad enough, Prime Minister Nehru was to add his touch to the sordid and humiliating drama of 19 November. Three events bear recounting. First, despite the magnitude of the disaster, the prime minister continued to vacillate on the question of who should now lead the army. What was needed was a self-confident, mentally secure, professionally competent chief who would with a firm hand inspire intrepidity and determination in the rank and file he commanded. The defeated army needed to be jolted out of the compliant and irresolute ways into which it had sunk. One of the main reasons for this state of affairs was Nehru's own insecurities. Unfortunately, even after all that had happened, those prejudices continued to weigh him down. Krishna Menon had been replaced as the defence minister on 1 November, with Nehru himself taking charge of the ministry. Interestingly, a few days before the Nehru-Thorat meeting, Menon had suggested to Nehru that should Thapar be removed, Thorat would be the ideal choice to replace him.

According to unconfirmed sources, even at this stage, Nehru wanted to appoint Kaul as the COAS. However, President Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan made it clear that he would not endorse that decision. The next option was the Western Army Commander, Lieutenant General Daulet Singh, who was sounded out but politely refused. Thorat being summoned by Nehru to Delhi indicates that on the morning of 19 November, the prime minister was still weighing the various options available to him. Thorat's sarcastic retort about Krishna Menon had sent Nehru, a man of strong likes and dislikes, into a fit of rage. It is quite likely that the prime minister in that very moment decided in favour of Lieutenant General Joyanto Nath